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This article is about the beverage made from Camellia sinensis.

Tea is an [aromatic beverage](#) prepared by pouring hot or [boiling water](#) over [cured](#) or fresh leaves of *[Camellia sinensis](#)*, an [evergreen shrub](#) native to [East Asia](#) which originated in the borderlands of [south-western China](#), [north-east India](#) and [northern Myanmar](#).^{[3][4][5]} Tea is also made, but rarely, from the leaves of *[Camellia taliensis](#)*.^{[6][7][8]} After plain [water](#), tea is the most widely consumed drink in the world.^[9] There are many types of tea; some have a cooling, slightly bitter, and [astringent](#) flavour, while others have profiles that include sweet, nutty, floral, or grassy [notes](#).^[10] Tea has a [stimulating](#) effect in humans, primarily due to its [caffeine](#) content.^[11]

An early credible record of tea drinking dates to the third century AD, in a medical text written by Chinese physician [Hua Tuo](#).^[12] It was popularised as a recreational drink during the Chinese [Tang dynasty](#), and tea drinking spread to other East Asian countries. [Portuguese priests](#) and merchants introduced it to Europe during the 16th century.^[13] During the 17th century, drinking tea became fashionable among the British, who later started to plant tea on a large scale in [India](#), where it had previously been used only as a medicine.

The term [herbal tea](#) refers to drinks not made from *Camellia sinensis*. They are the infusions of fruit, leaves, or [other plant parts](#), such as [steeps](#) of [rosehip](#), [chamomile](#), or [rooibos](#). These may be called *tisanes* or *herbal infusions* to prevent confusion with tea made from the tea plant.

Etymology

The [etymology](#) of the various words for *tea* reflects the history of transmission of tea drinking and trade from China.^[14] Nearly all of the words for tea worldwide fall into three broad groups: *te*, *cha* and *chai*, present in English as *tea*, *cha* or *char*, and *chai*. The earliest of the three to enter English is *cha*, which came in the 1590s via the Portuguese, who traded in [Macao](#) and picked up the [Cantonese](#) pronunciation of the word.^{[15][16]} The more common *tea* form arrived in the 17th century via the Dutch, who acquired it either indirectly from the Malay *teh*, or directly from the *tê* pronunciation in [Min Chinese](#).^[15] The third form *chai* (meaning "spiced tea") originated from a northern

Chinese pronunciation of *cha*, which travelled overland to Central Asia and [Persia](#) where it picked up a Persian ending *yi*. The Chinese word for tea itself was perhaps derived from the non-Sinitic languages of the botanical homeland of the tea plant in south-west China (or [Burma](#)), possibly from an archaic [Austro-Asiatic](#) root word **la*, meaning "leaf".^[17]

Origin and history

Botanical origin

Tea plants are native to East Asia and the probable center of origin of tea is near the source of the [Irrawaddy River](#) from where it spread out fan-wise into southeast China, Indo-China and [Assam](#). The natural home of the tea plant is considered to be within the comparatively small fan-shaped area between [Nagaland](#), [Manipur](#) and [Mizoram](#) along the [Burma](#) frontier in the west, through [China](#) as far as the [Zhejiang](#) Province in the east, and from this line generally south through the hills to Burma and [Thailand](#) to [Vietnam](#). The west–east axis indicated above is about 2,400 km long extending from longitude 95°–120°E. The north–south axis covers about 1,920 km, starting from the northern part of Burma, latitude 29°N passing through [Yunnan](#), [Tongkin](#), Thailand, [Laos](#) and on to Annam, reaching latitude 11°N.^[18]

Chinese (small-leaf) type tea (*C. sinensis* var. *sinensis*) may have originated in southern China possibly with hybridization of unknown wild tea relatives. Since there are no known wild populations of this tea, its origin is speculative.^{[19][20]}

Given their genetic differences forming distinct [clades](#), Chinese Assam-type tea (*C. sinensis* var. *assamica*) may have two parentages – one being found in southern [Yunnan](#) ([Xishuangbanna](#), [Pu'er City](#)) and the other in western Yunnan ([Lincang](#), [Baoshan](#)). Many types of Southern Yunnan Assam tea have been hybridized with the closely related species [Camellia taliensis](#). Unlike Southern Yunnan Assam tea, Western Yunnan Assam tea shares many genetic similarities with Indian Assam-type tea (also *C. sinensis* var. *assamica*). Thus, Western Yunnan Assam tea and Indian Assam tea both may have originated from the same parent plant in the area where southwestern China, Indo-Burma, and Tibet meet. However, as the Indian Assam tea shares no [haplotypes](#) with Western Yunnan Assam tea, Indian Assam tea is likely to have originated from an independent domestication. Some Indian Assam tea appears to have hybridized with the species [Camellia pubicosta](#).^{[19][20]}

Assuming a generation of 12 years, Chinese small-leaf tea is estimated to have diverged from Assam tea around 22,000 years ago, while Chinese Assam tea and Indian Assam tea diverged 2,800 years ago. The divergence of Chinese small-leaf tea and Assam tea would correspond to the last [glacial maximum](#).^{[19][20]}

Early tea drinking

People in ancient East Asia ate tea for centuries, perhaps even [millennia](#), before ever consuming it as a beverage. They would nibble on the leaves raw, add them to [soups](#) or [greens](#), or [ferment](#) them and chew them as [areca nut](#) is [chewed](#).^[22]

Tea drinking may have begun in the region of [Yunnan](#), where it was used for medicinal purposes. It is believed that in [Sichuan](#), "people began to boil tea leaves for consumption into a concentrated liquid without the addition of other leaves or herbs, thereby using tea as a bitter yet stimulating drink, rather than as a medicinal concoction."^[5]

Chinese legends attribute the invention of tea to the mythical [Shennong](#) (in central and northern China) in 2737 BC, although evidence suggests that tea drinking may have been introduced from southwest China.^[21] The earliest written records of tea come from China. The word *tú* 荼 appears in the [Shijing](#) and other ancient texts to signify a kind of "bitter vegetable" (苦菜), and it is possible that it referred to many different plants such as [sow thistle](#), [chicory](#), or [smartweed](#),^[23] as well as tea.^[24] In the [Chronicles of Huayang](#), it was recorded that the [Ba](#) people in Sichuan presented *tu* to the [Zhou](#) king. The [Qin](#) later conquered the state of [Ba](#) and its neighbour [Shu](#), and according to the 17th century scholar [Gu Yanwu](#) who wrote in *Ri Zhi Lu* (日知錄): "It was after the Qin had taken Shu that they learned how to drink tea."^[2] Another possible early reference to tea is found in a letter written by the [Qin dynasty](#) general Liu Kun who requested that some "real tea" to be sent to him.^[25]

The earliest known physical evidence^[26] of tea was discovered in 2016 in the mausoleum of [Emperor Jing of Han](#) in [Xi'an](#), indicating that tea from the genus *Camellia* was drunk by [Han dynasty](#) emperors as early as the second century BC.^[27] The Han dynasty work "The Contract for a Youth", written by [Wang Bao](#) in 59 BC,^[28] contains the first known reference to boiling tea. Among the tasks listed to be undertaken by the youth, the contract states that "he shall boil tea and fill the utensils" and "he shall buy

tea at Wuyang".^[2] The first record of tea cultivation is dated to this period, during which tea was cultivated on Meng Mountain (蒙山) near [Chengdu](#).^[29] Another early credible record of tea drinking dates to the 3rd century AD, in a medical text by the Chinese physician [Hua Tuo](#), who stated, "to drink bitter t'u constantly makes one think better."^[30] However, before the [Tang dynasty](#), tea-drinking was primarily a southern Chinese practice centered in [Jiankang](#).^[31] Tea was disdained by the [Northern dynasties](#) aristocrats, who describe it as inferior to yogurt.^{[32][33]} It became widely popular during the Tang dynasty, when it spread to Korea, [Japan](#), and Vietnam. *The Classic of Tea*, a treatise on tea and its preparations, was written by the 8th century Chinese writer, [Lu Yu](#). The current Chinese word for tea (茶) appeared in *The Classic of Tea* by removing a stroke from the word *tu*.^[34] Lu was known to have influenced tea drinking on a large part in China.^[35]

Developments

Through the centuries, a variety of techniques for processing tea, and a number of different forms of tea, were developed. During the Han and [Six Dynasties](#), tea was steamed and pounded, shaped into cake form, slowly dried over low fire, and suspended to air dry. Chunks of tea were then boiled to drink, flavoured with orange peels, [jujube](#), mint, ginger or [scallion](#).^[36] Tea was similarly prepared in cake form during the Tang dynasty, but [Lu Yu](#) disparaged the use of various condiments to flavour the tea apart from salt.^[37] By the [Song dynasty](#), loose-leaf tea was developed and became popular. During the [Yuan](#) and [Ming](#) dynasties, unoxidized tea leaves were first stirred in a hot dry pan, then rolled and air-dried, a process that stops the [oxidation](#) process that would have turned the leaves dark, thereby allowing tea to remain green. In the 15th century, [oolong](#) tea, in which the leaves are allowed to partially oxidize before being heated in the pan, was developed.^[31] Western tastes, however, favoured the fully oxidized [black tea](#), and the leaves were allowed to oxidize further. [Yellow tea](#) was an accidental discovery in the production of green tea during the Ming dynasty, when apparently careless practices allowed the leaves to turn yellow, which yielded a different flavour.^[38]

Worldwide spread

Tea was first introduced to Western priests and merchants in China during the 16th century, at which time it was termed *chá*.^[13] The earliest European reference to tea, written as *chiai*, came from *Delle navigationi e viaggi* written by Venetian [Giambattista Ramusio](#) in 1545.^[39] The first recorded shipment of tea by a European nation was in 1607 when the Dutch East India Company moved a cargo of tea from [Macao](#) to Java, then two years later, the Dutch bought the first assignment of tea which was from [Hirado](#) in Japan to be shipped to Europe.^[40] Tea became a fashionable drink in [The Hague](#) in the Netherlands, and the Dutch introduced the drink to [Germany](#), [France](#), and across the Atlantic to [New Amsterdam](#) (New York).^[41]

In 1567, Russian people came in contact with tea when [Cossack](#) leaders ([atamans](#)) [Petrov](#) and [Yalyshev](#) visited China.^[42] The Mongolian Khan donated to [Tsar Michael I](#) four [poods](#) (65–70 kg) of tea in 1638.^[43] According to [Jeremiah Curtin](#),^[44] it was possibly in 1636^[45] that [Vassili Starkov](#) was sent as envoy to the [Altyn Khan](#). He was given 250 pounds of tea as a gift to the tsar. Starkov at first refused, seeing no use for a load of dead leaves, but the Khan insisted. Thus was tea introduced to Russia. In 1679, Russia concluded a treaty on regular tea supplies from China via [camel caravan](#) in exchange for furs. It is today considered the *de facto* national beverage.

The first record of tea in English came from a letter written by [Richard Wickham](#), who ran an [East India Company](#) office in Japan, writing to a merchant in [Macao](#) requesting "the best sort of chaw" in 1615. [Peter Mundy](#), a traveller and merchant who came across tea in [Fujian](#) in 1637, wrote, "*chaa* – only water with a kind of herb boyled in it".^{[46][47]} Tea was sold in a coffee house in London in 1657, [Samuel Pepys](#) tasted tea in 1660, and [Catherine of Braganza](#) took the tea-drinking habit to the English court when she married [Charles II](#) in 1662. Tea, however, was not widely consumed in the British Isles until the 18th century and remained expensive until the latter part of that period. English drinkers preferred to add sugar and milk to black tea, and black tea overtook green tea in popularity in the 1720s.^[48] Tea smuggling during the 18th century led to the general public being able to afford and consume tea. The British government removed the tax on tea, thereby eliminating the smuggling trade, by 1785.^[49] In Britain and Ireland, tea was initially consumed as a luxury item on special occasions, such as religious festivals, wakes, and domestic work gatherings. The price of tea in Europe fell steadily during the 19th century, especially after Indian tea began to arrive in large quantities; by the late 19th century tea had become an everyday beverage for all levels of society.^[50] The popularity of tea played a role in historical events – the [Tea Act](#) of 1773 provoked the [Boston Tea Party](#) that escalated into the [American Revolution](#). The

need to address the issue of British trade deficit because of the trade in tea resulted in the [Opium Wars](#). The Qing [Kangxi Emperor](#) had banned foreign products from being sold in China, decreeing in 1685 that all goods bought from China must be paid for in silver coin or bullion.^[51] Traders from other nations then sought to find another product, in this case opium, to sell to China to earn back the silver they were required to pay for tea and other commodities. The subsequent attempts by the Chinese Government to curtail the trade in opium led to war.^[52]

Chinese small-leaf-type tea was introduced into India in 1836 by the British in an attempt to break the Chinese monopoly on tea.^[53] In 1841, [Archibald Campbell](#) brought seeds of [Chinese tea](#) from the [Kumaun](#) region and experimented with planting tea in [Darjeeling](#). The Alubari [tea garden](#) was opened in 1856, and [Darjeeling tea](#) began to be produced.^[54] In 1848, [Robert Fortune](#) was sent by the [East India Company](#) on a mission to China to bring the tea plant back to Great Britain. He began his journey in high secrecy as his mission occurred in the lull between the [First Opium War](#) and the [Second Opium War](#).^[55] The Chinese tea plants he brought back were introduced to the [Himalayas](#), though most did not survive. The British had discovered that a different variety of tea was endemic to [Assam](#) and the northeast region of India, which was then hybridized with Chinese small-leaf-type tea. Using Chinese planting and cultivation techniques, the British colonial government established a tea industry by offering land in Assam to any European who agreed to cultivate it for export.^[53] Tea was originally consumed only by [Anglo-Indians](#); however, it became widely popular in India in the 1950s because of a successful advertising campaign by the India Tea Board.^[53] The British introduced tea industry to Sri Lanka (then Ceylon) in 1867.^[56]